

UAE Presidential Court

MOHAMED MEETS TURKISH FOREIGN MINISTER

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan met Hakan Fidan, Minister of Foreign Affairs of Turkey, at Qasr Al Shati. They discussed bilateral relations and the importance of strengthening cooperation across various fields. They also discussed developments in the Middle East, with a focus on efforts to uphold the ceasefire in Gaza.

More countries in US visa ban list

Freeze applies to 75 countries including Russia, Pakistan, Iran

DUBAI
BY JAY HILOTIN
Senior Assistant Editor

The United States has ordered a complete and indefinite suspension of immigrant visa processing for citizens of 75 countries. The freeze, announced by the US State Department and confirmed by the White House, takes effect on January 21, and applies to countries including Russia, Pakistan, Iran, Afghanistan, Somalia, Brazil, Nigeria, Thailand, Egypt and dozens of others. “The State Department is pausing immigrant visa pro-

cessing for 75 countries,” a State Department spokesperson said on Wednesday, confirming President Donald Trump’s latest and most sweeping move yet to restrict immigration. White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said on X that Somalia was among the countries affected, along with Russia and Iran, while linking to a Fox News report that said the list also included countries with friendly ties to Washington such as Brazil, Egypt and Thailand. Financial firewall The move creates what officials describe as a financial firewall, aimed at ensuring immigrants arrive fully self-funded and do not rely on public benefits. Secretary of State Marco Rubio framed the policy starkly, declaring:

“No more public charge free-loaders.” The freeze operationalises tighter “public charge” rules rolled out in November, expanding a Trump-era doctrine that requires immigrants to prove they will not draw on taxpayer-funded welfare, Medicaid, housing assistance or other social benefits. The visa freeze comes amid a broader Trump administration immigration offensive. The State Department said earlier this week it has revoked more than 100,000 visas since Trump’s return to office — a one-year record. The Department of Homeland Security has reported that more than 605,000 people have been deported, while 2.5 million others left the US voluntarily. SEE ALSO P11

US sanctions Iran officials over protests

TRUMP STRIKES CAUTIOUS TONE, SAYS WASHINGTON ‘WATCHING’ IRAN

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The US yesterday imposed fresh sanctions on Iranian security officials and banking networks, accusing them of orchestrating a violent crackdown on nationwide protests and laundering billions of dollars in oil revenues, even as signs emerged that tensions around Iran were easing both on the streets and across the wider region. Included in yesterday’s sanctions is the secretary of the Supreme Council for National Security, whom the Treasury Department accuses of being one of the first officials to call for violence against Iranian protesters. The Treasury Department’s Office of Foreign Assets Control also designated 18 people and companies that the US says have participated in laundering money from sales of Iranian oil to foreign markets as part of a shadow banking network of sanctioned Iranian financial institutions Bank Melli and Shahr Bank Protests subside The sanctions come as visible protests in Iran appear to have subsided following days of intense unrest and a sweeping communications blackout. The sound of gunfire, which had been reported for several consecutive nights, has also faded. Iranian state media has continued to announce waves of arrests, branding detainees as “terrorists” and reporting efforts to locate Starlink satellite internet

In the Gulf, the security warning level at the US Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar was lowered, sources told Reuters, after a heightened alert.

dishes, one of the few remaining ways for protesters to communicate with the outside world amid the internet shutdown. President Donald Trump struck a cautious tone, saying Washington was “watching it and seeing what the process is,” after indicating he had been told executions of protesters had stopped. The remarks helped ease market fears, with oil prices falling and US stocks rising. In the Gulf, the security warning level at the US Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar was lowered. Iran reopened its airspace after closing it for more than four hours early yesterday without explanation. Iran, meanwhile, signalled defiance. In a call with Saudi Foreign Minister Prince Faisal Bin Farhan, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Tehran would “defend itself against any foreign threat”, while also urging condemnation of foreign interference. The UN Security Council was scheduled to meet later yesterday for a briefing on Iran, as the G7 warned it was prepared to impose additional sanctions if violence resumed.

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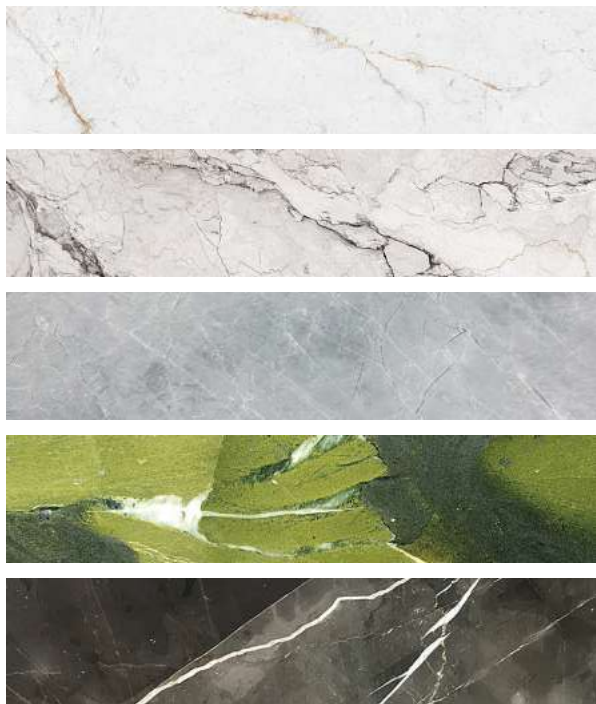
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